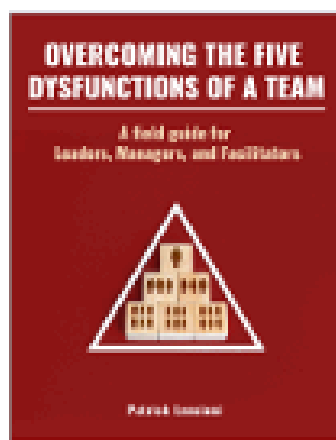




Overcoming the Five Dysfunctions of a Team

A Field Guide for Leaders, Managers and Facilitators

PATRICK LENCIONI



The Big "So What"

The book was written as a follow-up to best-seller *The Five Dysfunctions of a Team*, to provide a guide for leaders and practitioners to apply the concepts in the original book. It offers specific and practical guidelines for executives (be it leaders, practitioners or team players) who wish to understand **how to achieve outstanding results through great teams**.

Introduction



Teamwork can be hard to measure and achieve. Yet, **when you get it right, it can deliver seemingly-impossible results, and become a source of sustainable competitive advantage** for your company in today's rapidly changing world. **Teamwork can also deliver a sense of fulfilment for its members**, with positive spill-over effects beyond the workplace.

Overview - The 5 Dysfunctions of a Team

Using a fable in his earlier book, Lencioni illustrated how the absence of these 5 elements – trust, conflict, commitment, accountability and results - can cripple teams. In this book, he starts by defining each area, and outlines how their lack can handicap teams, and how to overcome them. **Each ingredient is important not so much in itself, but in laying the foundation upon which the next ingredient is built, to deliver the ultimate goal of results.**

KEY QUOTES

"Teamwork remains the one sustainable competitive advantage that has been largely untapped."

"When people come together and set aside individual needs for the good of the whole, they can accomplish what might have looked impossible on paper."

"A team is a relatively small number of people (anywhere from three to twelve) that shares common goals as well as the rewards and responsibilities for achieving them. Team members readily set aside their individual or personal needs for the greater good of the group."



KEY QUOTES

"Teamwork doesn't require great intellectual insights or masterful tactics. More than anything else, it comes down to courage and persistence."

Team Foundations



Before you move into team-building, there are 2 fundamental questions to ask yourselves:



Are we really a team?

A team should be small (3-12 people) and must share common goals. If your group doesn't fulfil these criteria, you may need to regroup or form a smaller group that does.



Are we ready to do what it takes?

Building a real team requires members to invest time and energy, and to get uncomfortable. Are you and your team members ready for that?

With these prerequisites out of the way, we can now focus on addressing each of the 5 Team Dysfunctions, and converting them into Success Factors.

Have each team member share 3 items:

- Where they grew up;
- Number of kids in their family; and
- The biggest childhood challenge as a kid.

For example, members may have assumed that someone is cold and unfriendly. However when they realize that he merely has trouble expressing himself due to his strict upbringing, they immediately become more understanding and empathic.



Behavioural Profiling

This provides an unbiased and dependable way for people to (a) **validate and share their strengths and weaknesses**, and (b) **have a common and objective lingo to discuss these strengths and weaknesses**. There are numerous profiling tools available, though Lencioni personally recommends the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI).

Teams can do their assessments prior, then have an off-site meeting to review and share their profiles (after a short briefing). After such meetings, encourage people to have the profile placed visibly at their work-desk, to share them with their direct reports, and get together soon to discuss/ share how they have applied the insights at work.



2. Mastering Conflict

"Good conflict" is about open, constructive and passionate debates about issues that affect organizational success. However, this seldom exists because most teams are trying to maintain artificial harmony by avoiding difficult issues. Others, on the other hand, waste time and energy managing perceived personal attacks, manipulating conversations and trying to win arguments (rather than solve real problems).

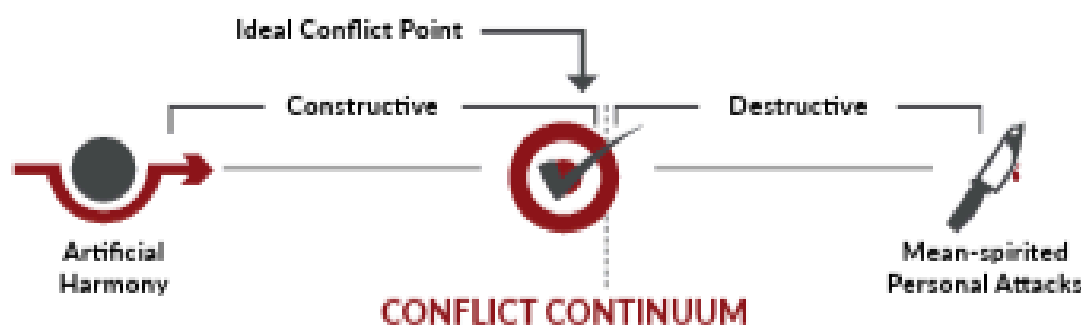
KEY QUOTES

"I will never get tired of watching the reticence and guardedness of untrusting teammates melt away as they acknowledge to one another what makes them tick. Without fail, there is laughter, teasing, relief and insight. And that is exactly when the seeds of trust begin to grow."

"As with any new information, if it is not put to use and discussed, it quickly grows stale."

"When I talk about conflict on a team, I'm talking about productive, ideological conflict: passionate, unfiltered debate around issues of importance to the team."

"When vulnerability-based trust exists, team members say everything that needs to be said, and there is nothing left to talk about behind closed doors."



In theory, the ideal level of conflict would be at the end of the constructive zone, just before it tips into the destructive zone. However occasional destructive conflict gives the team an opportunity to work through difficult issues, building deeper trust and confidence.

Conflict is inherently uncomfortable. Hence, **trust is an important (and necessary) foundation that allows members to push one another outside their emotional comfort zones.** Here are several tools to facilitate constructive conflict:



Conflict Profiling.

Different people view and handle conflict differently, due to their personality, cultural background, family background etc. Similar to personality profiling, it is useful for **team members to understand one another's conflict profiles by doing an assessment** (e.g. using the MBIT or Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Mode instrument).



Conflict Norming.

With an understanding of their conflict profiles, members should **jointly establish their rules of engagement** (e.g. whether to stay emotion-free or express emotions freely, whether interruption is acceptable during debates). Once agreed, everyone is accountable to uphold the norms.



Encouraging Conflict.

Even with mutual understanding and team norms, most people tend to shy away from conflict. Leaders play an important role in encouraging conflict:

KEY QUOTES

"The only thing that really matters is this: are they holding back their opinions? Members of great teams do not."

"When a team recovers from an incident of destructive conflict, it builds confidence that it can survive such an event, which in turn builds trust."

"When people self-identify and publicly declare their outlook on conflict, they become much more open to adjusting it to whatever team norms need to be established."

"The leader is going to have to be ready to not only light the fuse of good conflict but to gently fan the flames for a while too."



The leader must mine for conflict, i.e. identify when real issues are being buried and create opportunities to unearth them.



When team members are in the midst of an atypical debate, leaders should also give “real-time permission” by reassuring them that such conflict is desirable, even if it's uncomfortable.



Rather than waste time running boring meetings with no conflict nor breakthrough, leaders must use meetings productively to surface real issues and critical opinions. They can start meetings with a “hook”, creating a sense of urgency around why the issues at hand must be properly addressed, before mining for conflict.



Conflict Resolution.

As more conflict arises, leaders will need to know how to effectively resolve them. Lencioni provides a series of tools to help teams identify and remove individual, relationship, environmental and informational obstacles, as well as to assess and improve their conflict tendencies.



3. Achieve Commitment

Team commitment isn't about consensus, but the willingness to embrace a decision without consensus. There are 2 key ingredients:



Buy-In.

Contrary to common belief, most people are willing to buy in to a decision - even if it is different from their own suggestions - so long as their own ideas have been considered and explained in the context of the final decision.

KEY QUOTES

"The ultimate penalty of boring meetings is bad decisions, not to mention wasted time."

"Commitment is ...the ability to defy a lack of consensus."

"Commitment is not consensus. Waiting for everyone on a team to agree intellectually on a decision is a good recipe for mediocrity delay, and frustration."

This is why conflict (facilitated by good leadership) is so instrumental – when team members are confident that all options, perspectives and opinions have been aired, they are more willing to stand behind the decision despite their initial disagreement.



Clarity.

Often, people walk away from a meeting with different understanding of what has just been agreed. Without clarity and alignment, there can be no real commitment. To remove assumptions and ambiguity:

- Clarify commitment. Before the end of each meeting, the leader must write down the key decisions that have been made. Any discrepancies must be identified and ironed out before the decision is announced.
- Cascade the commitment. Each team member must also communicate (verbally or in person) the decisions to their staff within 24 hours of the meeting. This forces the team members to become equally clear and committed to the decision.



Besides commitment to specific decisions, every team needs to commit to broader issues or principles like purpose, mission, values, strategy and goals. To rally the team around a common cause, you can establish "thematic goals", i.e. a common, unifying goal that all team members can constantly thinking about and work towards in their daily work.

KEY QUOTES

"Most people don't need to have their ideas adopted...in order to buy in to a decision. They just want to have their ideas heard, understood, considered, and explained within the context of the ultimate decision."

"It is amazing to me how a group of intelligent, highly educated adults, all of whom speak the same language, can sit in a room for two hours of discussion, and then leave the room under the false impression that everyone is on the same page."



4. Embrace Accountability

Accountability in the context of this book is about **team members' willingness to hold one another to live up to the group's decisions and performance standards**. Strong teams don't depend on the leader as the main source of accountability; **their true motivation to perform comes from peer pressure** and the desire not to let down a fellow team member.

To kickstart the culture of accountability:

- **Leaders must first set the tone.** Rather than just manage results (which are only visible at the end), they must be prepared to get uncomfortable and uphold behavioural standards (e.g. confronting a staff who is badmouthing a company initiative, or someone who is not handling a task to expectation); and
- **Leaders need to reinforce the value of constructive feedback.** People are naturally resistant to offering critical feedback, hence members must be educated that when they withhold constructive feedback, they are actually letting down their peers.

Here are 2 tools to help deepen accountability and performance:



Team Effectiveness Exercise. This is suitable for teams that already have some level of trust and experience working together.

- Set aside at least 1 hour. Have every member write down their answers for these 2 questions, for every other team member (except themselves):
 1. "What's the 1 most important behaviour demonstrated by this person which strengthens our team?"
 2. "What's the 1 most important behaviour demonstrated by this person which can sometimes derail the team?"

KEY QUOTES

"Peer pressure and the distaste for letting down a colleague will motivate a team player more than any fear of authoritative punishment or rebuke."

"By holding back we are hurting not only the team, but also our teammates themselves."

- Members share their answers for Question 1, focusing first on the leader, then repeat the process for Question 2. The leader can seek clarification, but can't respond to the feedback. The same process is then repeated for the rest of the team members.
- After the exercise, team members must email their areas of strengths and weaknesses to the leader and review/discuss those areas again in a few months.



Use meetings to build accountability.

- Start each meeting with a “lightning round” by having each team member summarize (in less than 30 seconds) their top 3 priorities that week. Other team members can suggest more important areas that the member should focus on, if any.
- Have a scoreboard or radar screen where key goals can be tracked and made visible during meetings (see next segment)

KEY QUOTES

“What's critical is that team members know that the areas that were identified will not go away, and that they will have to answer for their progress in the not-too-distant future.”

“Teams have to eliminate ambiguity and interpretation when it comes to success.”



5. Focus On Results

Even when a team has successfully overcome the previous dysfunctions, they still may not achieve results because of:

- **Lack of clear measurements.** It is tempting to go with a vague interpretation of success, as it gives us room to manoeuvre and change our goal posts. The key to success is to **pick 1 or 2 goals** (e.g. market share, customer satisfaction, revenue, year-on-year growth) **that the team can rally around, and to commit the goal(s) publicly as early as possible.**
- **Self-interest/ preservation.** Our natural inclination is to put our self-interest first before others' (including our teams). This tendency can be broken down into:

- **Ego.** Much as we want our teams to win, we usually want to win first as individuals. A team can only be strong if each member is not satisfied until the collective results of the group are achieved.
- Our needs in terms of **career development and money** can distract us from the team's collective goals. Most people are not comfortable sharing such concerns, yet they can fester if not addressed. Only when there's a strong foundation of trust in the team, can members be encouraged to surface such personal concerns for solutions
- Given a choice, most leaders will prioritize their **own departments** (or the teams they lead) over the cross-departmental teams that they are members of.

To overcome members' natural self-interests, **the only way is to make the win-win, common team goals visible and the constant focus of the team's attention.** This can be done through a **Scoreboard**, which clearly lists one visible and largely-quantitative metric (that summarizes the team's progress or success), and a qualitative assessment that summarizes the supportive objectives or thematic goal.

Other Details in the Book to Look out For



This is a concise and easy-to-read book, focusing on practical tools, exercises, assessments and real-world examples for overcoming the 5 dysfunctions of teams, to deliver great results. For each of the tips covered in this summary, Lencioni provides case studies/ examples, including facilitation tips for leaders and practitioners.

To give a better idea of what is involved in the team-building process, he also provides:

- Answers to a list of commonly asked questions, e.g. How long it takes to build a team, whether to manage the process inhouse or via an external consultant/ facilitator;

KEY QUOTES

"Result oriented teams establish their own measurements for success. They don't allow themselves the wiggle room for subjectivity."

"The key to success for a team is that its members go beyond barter and compromise to embrace a collective pursuit of the best interests of the whole."